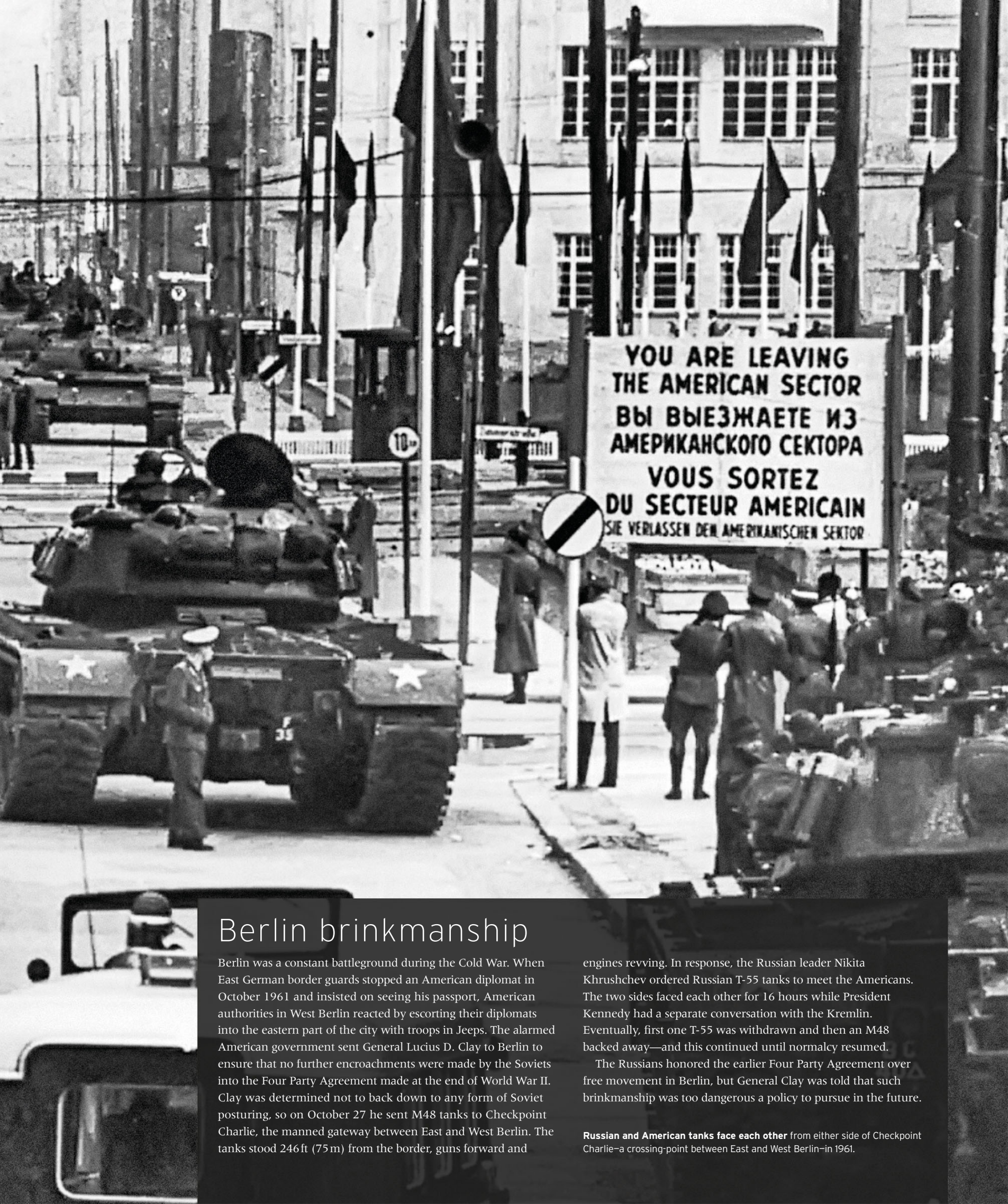




Berlin brinkmanship

Berlin was a constant battleground during the Cold War. When East German border guards stopped an American diplomat in October 1961 and insisted on seeing his passport, American authorities in West Berlin reacted by escorting their diplomats into the eastern part of the city with troops in Jeeps. The alarmed American government sent General Lucius D. Clay to Berlin to ensure that no further encroachments were made by the Soviets into the Four Party Agreement made at the end of World War II. Clay was determined not to back down to any form of Soviet posturing, so on October 27 he sent M48 tanks to Checkpoint Charlie, the manned gateway between East and West Berlin. The tanks stood 246 ft (75 m) from the border, guns forward and

engines revving. In response, the Russian leader Nikita Khrushchev ordered Russian T-55 tanks to meet the Americans. The two sides faced each other for 16 hours while President Kennedy had a separate conversation with the Kremlin. Eventually, first one T-55 was withdrawn and then an M48 backed away—and this continued until normalcy resumed.

The Russians honored the earlier Four Party Agreement over free movement in Berlin, but General Clay was told that such brinkmanship was too dangerous a policy to pursue in the future.

Russian and American tanks face each other from either side of Checkpoint Charlie—a crossing-point between East and West Berlin—in 1961.